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Animals in the Bible

Animals, general

1 Animals, general

- 1.1 Domestic animals, cattle, livestock, animal, living being
- 1.2 Animals that are ridden or made to carry loads
- 1.3 Wild or dangerous animals

A number of words in the Bible indicate "animals" or "creatures" in a general way without specifying a particular species. Almost all languages will have one or several words for creatures that are "living" or "breathing" or "souled" (the literal meaning of the English word "animal").

References:

Hebrew בְּהֵמָה (behemah) GEN 7:2, GEN 7:2, GEN 7:8, GEN 7:8, LEV 11:2, LEV 11:3, LEV 11:26, LEV 11:39, LEV 11:46, LEV 18:23, LEV 18:23, LEV 20:15, LEV 20:15, LEV 20:16, LEV 20:16, LEV 20:25, LEV 20:25

Hebrew חַי, חַיָּה, חֵיוָה (chay, chayah, cheva) GEN 1:28, GEN 1:30, GEN 6:19, GEN 8:17, LEV 11:47, LEV 11:47, PSA 104:25, DAN 2:38, DAN 4:9, DAN 4:11, DAN 4:12, DAN 4:13, DAN 4:18, DAN 4:20, DAN 4:22, DAN 4:29, DAN 5:21, DAN 7:3, DAN 7:5, DAN 7:6, DAN 7:7, DAN 7:7, DAN 7:11, DAN 7:12, DAN 7:17, DAN 7:19, DAN 7:23

Greek θήρ, θήρα (thēr) WIS 11:18, 2MA 4:25, 2MA 11:9, 3MA 5:31, 3MA 6:7

Greek ζῷον (zōon) HEB 13:11, 2PE 2:12, JUD 1:10, REV 4:6, REV 4:7, REV 4:7, REV 4:7, REV 4:7, REV 4:8, REV 4:9, REV 5:6, REV 5:8, REV 5:11, REV 5:14, REV 6:1, REV 6:3, REV 6:5, REV 6:6, REV 6:7, REV 7:11, REV 14:3, REV 15:7, REV 19:4

Greek κνώδαλον (knōdalon) WIS 11:15, WIS 16:1, WIS 17:9

Greek κτῆνος (ktēnos) 1ES 2:4, 1ES 2:6, 1ES 5:1, 1ES 8:50, 1ES 9:4, TOB 10:10, JDT 4:10, JDT 5:9, JDT 8:7, JDT 11:7, JDT 11:12, SIR 7:22, SIR 40:8, BAR 3:32, 1MA 1:47, 1MA 2:30, 1MA 2:38, 1MA 12:23

Greek τετράποδος (tetrapodos) BAR 3:32, 1MA 10:11, 4MA 1:34

Greek χερσαῖος (chersaios) WIS 19:19

Latin anima, animalis 2ES 6:47, 2ES 6:48, 2ES 11:39, 2ES 11:40

Latin bestia 2ES 5:8, 2ES 6:53, 2ES 7:65, 2ES 8:30

Latin creatura 2ES 5:45, 2ES 11:6

Latin quadrupes 2ES 7:65

Discussion:

The Hebrew word *behemah* carries a broad spectrum of meanings, including all of the divisions in this chapter: animal in general, domestic animal, animal that is ridden, and wild animal. This word occurs some 190 times. A few representative references have been given for this word in each category; for the most part the context will give an indication of which meaning is appropriate.

The words *chay, chayah* and *cheva* in Hebrew and *zōon* in Greek are derived from a root meaning "life," "to be alive". They can refer to any type of living creature. In some contexts the reference is to human beings in others to animals or to creatures that live in the water and in still others to all living creatures. However the reference is always to some form of animal life rather than to plants. In a few contexts the word *chay* functions as an adjective for example living "live" or "alive." While the word *chay* does not indicate any specific animal it will usually be possible to tell from the context which animal is intended. However in some references in Genesis, Ezekiel, and Revelation there are no clues as to what kinds of animals or beings are

meant. All we know is that they were alive. The words *tetrapodos* and *quadrupes* literally "four-footed" indicate animals in a general sense especially referring to mammals as opposed to snakes birds and other living creatures.

Special significance or symbolism:

In Genesis, Ezekiel, and Revelation it is clear that the "living beings" are somehow connected to God who gives life.

Translation:

In most languages a general term for something living will have to be translated differently according to the context. In contexts where the reference is clearly to people, an expression meaning "living person" is a good equivalent, while "living animal", "living creatures", and the like would be the best equivalents in other contexts. In some cases a general word for "animal" will be appropriate; compare the Contemporary English Version (CEV) at : "These people are no better than senseless animals. … " In contexts of sacrifice the preferred expressions would be "live dove", "live goat", or another live sacrificial animal, according to which one is identified specifically in the context.

REV 4:6: The word translated "living creatures" here means, in most contexts, "animals" but that specific meaning should not be used here. They are simply living beings, not classified either as animals or humans. They seem to be modeled after the living beings in EZK 1:5–EZK 1:14. In many cultures where there is a long Christian tradition employing a transliteration of "cherub" or "seraph" as the equivalent of "living creature" (and if translators feel that this term should continue to be employed), a footnote or a note in the glossary describing these creatures should be provided.

Domestic animals, cattle, livestock, animal, living being

1.1 Domestic animals, cattle, livestock, animal, living being

References:

Hebrew בְּהֵמָה (behemah) GEN 1:24, GEN 1:25, GEN 1:26, GEN 2:20, GEN 3:14, GEN 6:7, GEN 6:20, GEN 34:23, GEN 36:6, GEN 47:18, EXO 9:9, EXO 9:10, EXO 9:19, EXO 9:22, EXO 9:25

Hebrew בְּעִיר (beʿir) EXO 22:4, EXO 22:4, NUM 20:4, NUM 20:8, NUM 20:11, PSA 78:48

Hebrew מִקְנֶה (miqneh) GEN 4:20, GEN 13:2, GEN 13:7, GEN 26:14, GEN 29:7, GEN 30:29, GEN 31:9, GEN 31:18, GEN 33:17, GEN 34:5, GEN 34:23, GEN 36:6, GEN 36:7, GEN 46:6, GEN 46:32, GEN 46:34, GEN 47:6, GEN 47:16, GEN 47:17, GEN 47:18, EXO 9:3, EXO 9:4, EXO 9:6, EXO 9:7, EXO 9:19, EXO 9:20, EXO 9:21, EXO 10:26, EXO 12:38, EXO 17:3, EXO 34:19, NUM 20:19, NUM 31:9, NUM 32:1, NUM 32:4, NUM 32:16, NUM 32:26, DEU 3:19, JOS 1:14, JOS 14:4, JOS 22:8, JDG 6:5, JDG 18:21, 1SA 23:5, 1SA 30:20, 2KI 3:17, 1CH 5:9, 1CH 5:21, 1CH 7:21, 1CH 28:1, 2CH 14:14, 2CH 26:10, 2CH 32:29, JOB 1:3, JOB 1:10, JOB 36:33, PSA 78:48, ECC 2:7, ISA 30:23, JER 9:9, JER 49:32, EZK 38:12, EZK 38:13

Greek θρέμμα (thremma) JHN 4:12

Latin iumentum 2ES 6:53

Latin pecus 2ES 8:29

Discussion:

These words refer to all kinds of livestock viewed as possessions or "living riches". Although they are translated as "cattle" in some versions they are used in these versions with an archaic more general meaning equivalent to "domestic animals" or "livestock". The meaning includes cattle sheep goats camels and donkeys or in other words any animals kept in large numbers for both domestic and commercial purposes.

Special significance or symbolism:

In the time of the patriarchs Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob livestock were a measure of a man's wealth. A person who owned many livestock was considered "well off." Conversely a person without livestock was a man without status.

Translation:

The best equivalent is an inclusive expression covering all kinds of livestock animals.

Animals that are ridden or made to carry loads

1.2 Animals that are ridden or made to carry loads

References:

Hebrew בְּהֵמָה (behemah) NEH 2:12, NEH 2:12, NEH 2:14

Hebrew בְּעִיר (beʿir) GEN 45:17

Greek κτήνος (ktēnos) LUK 10:34, ACT 23:24, 1CO 15:39, REV 18:13

Discussion:

In this category are all animals that are ridden or made to carry loads. This includes donkeys camels horses mules and oxen. See specific treatments under "mammals".

Translation:

We cannot know for certain on which kind of animal the Good Samaritan placed the injured Jew. All we know is that it was an animal that was ridden or could carry a load. Thus many English translations have "beast" or "mount". But since we know that donkeys were the usual means of transport, we can surmise that a donkey was envisioned by Jesus when he told the parable. Thus some translations, such as NIV, have "donkey". The options then for the translator are to use an expression meaning "animal for riding" or "pack animal" or to use a word meaning "donkey".

ACT 23:24: Similarly we cannot know which kind of riding animals were provided for Paul when he left Jerusalem for Caesarea. Since we know that horses were the usual means of transport for the Romans, it is probable that they were horses. Here the translator can use either an expression like "animals to ride" or a word for "horses".

1CO 15:39: Here the context indicates that no specific group of animals is intended, and a general word meaning "animal" best fits this context.

REV 18:13: All English translations have "cattle" in this verse, since the word is plural and is parallel to "sheep". It is almost certain that donkeys were not intended by the writer in this context, since donkeys were not exported as merchandise.

Wild or dangerous animals

1.3 Wild or dangerous animals

References:

Hebrew בְּהֵמָה (behemah) DEU 28:26, DEU 32:24, 1SA 17:44, JER 7:33, JER 15:3, JER 16:4, JER 21:6, JER 34:20, JOL 1:20, JOL 2:22, MIC 5:7

Hebrew חַיָּה, חֵיוָה (chayah, cheva) GEN 2:20, GEN 3:1, GEN 3:14, GEN 37:20, GEN 37:33, EXO 23:11, EXO 23:29, LEV 17:13, LEV 26:6, LEV 26:22, DEU 7:22, 2SA 21:10, 2KI 14:9, 2CH 25:18, JOB 5:23, JOB 39:15, JOB 40:20, ISA 43:20, JER 12:9, JER 27:6, JER 28:14, EZK 31:6, EZK 31:13, EZK 34:5, EZK 34:8, EZK 38:20, EZK 39:4, EZK 39:17, HOS 2:14, HOS 2:20, HOS 4:3, HOS 13:8

Greek θηρίον (thērion) MRK 1:13, ACT 11:6, ACT 28:4, ACT 28:5, TIT 1:12, HEB 12:20, JAS 3:7, REV 6:8, REV 11:7, REV 13:1, REV 13:2, REV 13:3, REV 13:4, REV 13:4, REV 13:4, REV 13:11, REV 13:12, REV 13:12, REV 13:14, REV 13:14, REV 13:15, REV 13:15, REV 13:15, REV 13:17, REV 13:18, REV 14:9, REV 14:11, REV 15:2, REV 16:2, REV 16:10, REV 16:13, REV 17:3, REV 17:7, REV 17:8, REV 17:8, REV 17:11, REV 17:12, REV 17:13, REV 17:16, REV 17:17, REV 18:2, REV 19:19, REV 19:20, REV 19:20, REV 20:4, REV 20:10

Description:

These are animals that are wild or are dangerous to humans. It can refer not only to animals such as lions and wolves, but also to snakes.

Special significance or symbolism:

In the book of Revelation the "beast" is associated with great wickedness.

Translation:

The fact that *behemah, chayah* and *cheva* indicate a wild or dangerous animal can usually be determined by modifiers in the text, such as "evil", "wild", "of the field", "of the earth", or "of the forest".

In the books of the Maccabees the word *thērion*, literally "big animal" usually refers to the elephant. See 2.14 Elephant.

ACT 28:4; ACT 28:5: In verse 3 Paul is said to have been bitten by a viper (See 4.10 Viper), but in verses 4 and 5 in the Greek it is called "*to thērion* ("the dangerous creature"). In most English versions this is translated as "the snake", and in most languages this will be the natural thing to do. Some translations use an expression meaning "the poisonous thing".

HEB 12:20: In this verse the reference does not seem to be to dangerous animals in particular, but to animals generally. Many modern English versions translate *thērion* here as "an animal".

In all other cases for *thērion* an expression for "wild animal" or "dangerous animal" is used. The creature in Revelation, being symbolic in nature, is sometimes referred to in translations by the name of a particular animal that represents evil in the local culture (for example, a hyena). However, this should only be done as a very last resort, since the writer of Revelation uses a general rather than a specific word, leaving the reader to imagine what sort of dangerous animal he is referring to. Care should be taken to distinguish clearly between the "living creatures" of chapters 4–6, which represent good, and the "wild animals" of later chapters, which represent wickedness.

The following material is adapted from the UBS Handbook on the Revelation to John, comments on REV 11:7 and REV 13:1:

The word translated "beast" means simply "animal" and the American Translation (AT) and Phillips (Phps) translate here "the animal", which is a bit strange in English. A translator must find, if possible, a distinctive word for these creatures. Perhaps use can be made of words taken from legends or fairy tales, where fantastic animals are fairly common. Here something like "monster" or "wild beast", or even "ogre", may be appropriate. In certain languages where there are only the two categories, domesticated animals or wild animals, it will be necessary to define "beast" with a phrase such as "a terrible wild animal", "a huge, horrible animal", or even "a frightening, savage animal".